"IN THE BEGINNING..."

GENESIS 17

IN 5 MINUTES

When:

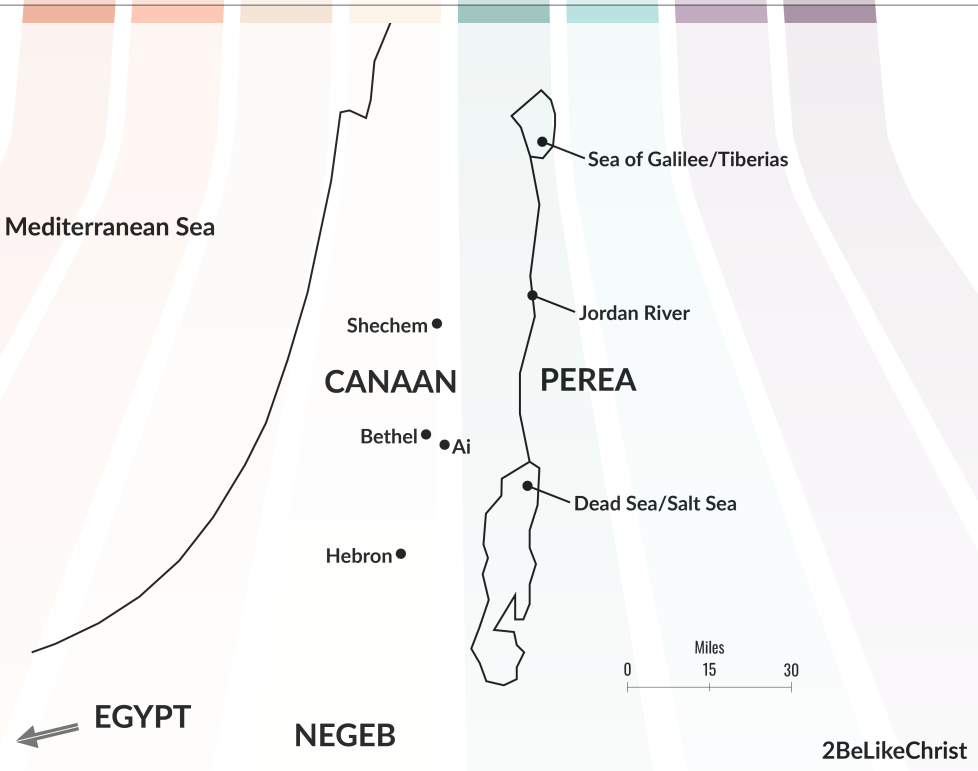
- Abram was born in approximately 1996 B.C. and died in 1821 B.C. (Gen 25:7).
- The events recorded in Genesis 17 happened when Abram was 99 years old (approximately 1897 B.C.).

Characters:

- **Abram** – A man from Ur of the Chaldeans who moved to Canaan at God's instruction. God promised to make his descendants a great nation and to give them the land of Canaan.
- **Sarai** – Abram's wife. She was barren and couldn't conceive children.

Where:

- In Genesis 17, God had a conversation with Abraham about the future of his family, but we are not told where this conversation took place.



Outline:

- GOD'S COVENANT WITH ABRAM AND THE SIGN OF CIRCUMCISION (17:1-14):
    + God spoke to Abram when He was 99 years old and reaffirmed His promises to him.
    + God promised Abram he would be the "father of a multitude of nations" and for that reason, God changed Abram's name to Abraham.
    + The covenant between God and Abraham was to be an "everlasting covenant."
    + He would give Abraham's descendants the land of Canaan and they were to worship Him as the one true God.
    + As a sign of the covenant, Abraham was to circumcise all his future male children and every male who lived in his house.
    + Infants born in Abraham's house were to be circumcised when they were 8 days old.
- GOD PROMISES ABRAHAM AND SARAI A SON (17:15-21):
    + God told Abraham Sarai's name was to be changed to Sarah, because she was going to give birth to a son.
    + Her son would be the father of nations and "kings of peoples."
    + Abraham laughed and expressed his doubts that a 100-year-old man and a 90-year-old woman could conceive a child.
    + He asked God if His promises could be fulfilled through Ishmael, Abraham's son with Hagar, but God told him it was not to be.
    + God would bless Ishmael, but Abraham's son with Sarah was the child through which God's everlasting covenant would be established.
- ABRAHAM'S HOUSEHOLD IS CIRCUMCISED (17:22-27):
    + After speaking with God, Abraham returned to his household and circumcised all the males, including himself.
    + Abraham was 99 years old, and Ishmael was 13 years old when they were circumcised.

Application:

- God loves to use incapable people to achieve great things.
- Abraham and Sarah couldn't naturally conceive children, but God used them to birth a nation of people who were central to His redemption story.
- This pattern is repeated throughout the Bible.
- If you are going to accomplish great things in the Kingdom of God, it won't be by your own strength and skill, it will happen as a result of God's power working through you as you humbly submit to His leading.